

A Setback for Peace

Bhutto's killing will bring about uncertainty in peace talks with India and lead to an increase in cross-border terrorism

For India, which was expecting the peace process with Pakistan to be revive, the assassination of Benazir Bhutto couldn't have come at a worse time. The killing has demonstrated again that Pakistan continues to be the epicenter of terrorism.

As the Indian leadership expressed shock and sent out its condolences to the bereaved family, South Block was monitoring the situation closely as the resultant chaos in the neighbourhood has security and strategic implications for India. "The manner of her going is a reminder of the common dangers that our region faces from cowardly acts of terrorism and of the need to eradicate this dangerous threat," remarked Prime Minister Manmohan Singh.

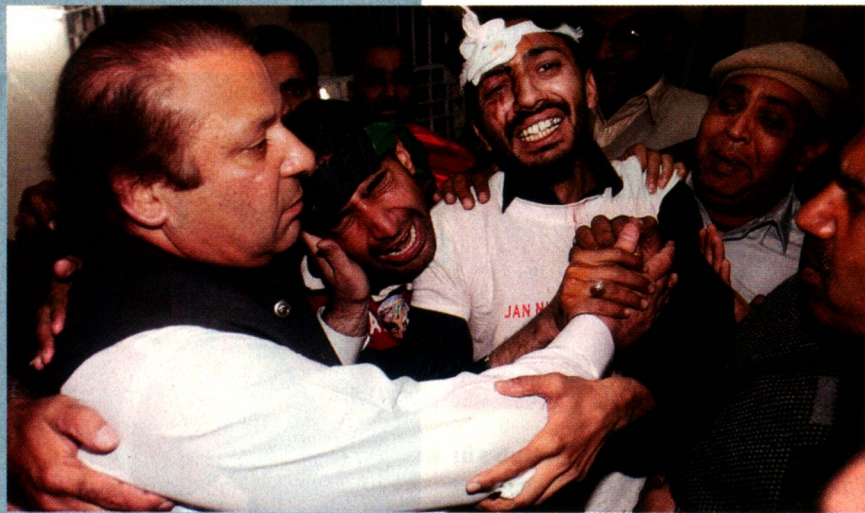
Her assassination is a setback that will weaken the democratic forces in Pakistan. This may even mean that the January 2008 elections may be postponed. And Musharraf may once again impose emergency, which may trigger another round of violence in the country. "Pakistan is headed for turmoil, which is a cause of concern for us. PPP was a dominant political party there and now the Army is going to play a predominant role," says former Indian High Commissioner to Pakistan G. Parthasarthy.

The weakening of Pakistan is not in India's interest because of the spillover effect it is likely to have. On the bilateral front, key issues like Jammu and Kashmir, terrorism, Siachen, besides strengthening of people-to-people-contact will now be put on the back burner and the composite dialogue process may be postponed further.

Experts believe that even though Bhutto was not connected to the peace talks with India, she was in support of the ongoing initiatives. "She would have accelerated the peace process as she was supportive of it and her death does not bode well

for the forces of democracy. Though I don't think the composite dialogue process will be off the track, any chaos in Pakistan is worrying for us," remarked S.K. Lambah, the prime minister's special envoy on Pakistan.

Besides, a bigger worry is that if the unrest in Pakistan continues, it will only lead to further instability and fundamentalists may gain ground. The country is already under siege by religious fundamentalists and terrorist groups whose



writ runs large in many provinces. These regions may slip further into chaos which may pose fresh threats for India, as cross border terrorism may escalate in 2008. And in case the chaos turns into anarchy and the army cedes control to fundamentalist groups, it may even endanger the safety of Pakistan's nuclear arsenal.

While Bhutto's death has snatched away a leader who had vowed to eliminate terror, it clearly demonstrates the inability of the Musharraf regime to fight terror. This incident should serve as an eye-opener for the international community that the situation is getting out of hand in Pakistan and there is an urgent need to take on terror elements head on before it is too late.

by Saurabh Shukla

internal political dynamic. Lt Gen Talat Masood, a former secretary of defence production, believes the nation state will hold. The new military chief General Ashfaq Kiani is expected to make the moment his own, says Masood, adding that, "The army is not keen on running the affairs of the state anymore".

The only other way that Pakistan could have some degree of control over its own political future is through the banding together of its political parties in a concerted effort to send Musharraf into oblivion and bring democracy back to a country which has lost not just its most prominent leader, but also its confidence.

Post Bhutto, should the PPP flounder or splinter, it would not bode well as it

FIGHT BACK: Sharif announced his party would boycott the elections

remains the only political party with roots in all provinces with some analysts already questioning the future of federal politics. "If PPP were to become marginalised, we would have only the army left as a federal force," says Islamabad-based Pakistan editor of the BBC Aamer Ahmed Khan.

Shortly before she returned to Pakistan in October Bhutto had written in a column for the *Washington Post*, "I do not know what awaits me, personally or politically... I pray for the best and prepare for the worst... I am going home to fight for the restoration of Pakistan's place in the community of democratic nations." Her eventful life could not achieve that dream but Bhutto's tragic death could become its own lasting and powerful legacy. ■